

A Ballot Battle  
Of Republicans  
Versus Citizens

States Set Up Hurdles  
to Stymie Initiatives

By KATE ZERNIKE

Voters frustrated by one-party control in Republican states over the last decade have increasingly turned to citizen-sponsored initiatives to enact policies that their legislatures won't. They expanded Medicaid, adopted paid sick leave, raised the minimum wage and safeguarded access to abortion.

Now, the legislators are striking back.

In North Dakota, Utah and South Dakota, legislatures are sponsoring measures on the November ballot that would raise the threshold for approving citizen amendments to 60 percent, not a simple majority.

In Missouri, the legislature placed a measure on the ballot that would set an even higher bar: Citizen-sponsored amendments to the state Constitution would have to win in each of the state's eight U.S. House districts. An initiative that wins 95 percent of the vote statewide could lose if it fails in a single district.

And in Florida, Gov. Ron DeSantis signed a bill imposing a raft of new requirements, fees and criminal penalties around collecting signatures on petitions for ballot measures. The result: All 22 initiatives proposed by citizens this year failed to qualify for the ballot.

The legislators argue that the nation's founders never intended a pure democracy, and that in a representative democracy, elected legislators are entrusted to carry out their own judgments. Moreover, opponents say, citizens' initiatives — established during the progressive era more than a century ago as a check on wealthy special-interest groups — now allow such groups to hijack the will of the people.

"We live in a republic," Stuart Adams, the president of the Utah

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3-Year Sentence  
For Ex-Sergeant  
In Bronx Death

By CHELSIA ROSE MARCIUS  
and HURUBIE MEKO

A former police sergeant was sentenced to at least three years in prison on Thursday for the killing of a Bronx man whom he had hit with a cooler as the man fled arrest on a motorbike.

The sentence capped a tumultuous case that tested how the legal system would respond when officers harmed or killed people, and ended with the first conviction of a New York Police Department officer for killing a civilian in a decade.

In February, the former sergeant, Erik Duran, 38, was convicted of second-degree manslaughter in the 2023 death of the man, Eric Duprey, 30. Mr. Duran, who asked a judge to decide the case instead of a jury, was immediately fired from the Police Department after the verdict.

Before his sentence was announced on Thursday, Mr. Duran stood up and turned toward Mr. Duprey's mother, Gretchen Soto, who was sitting in the courtroom gallery.

"I am really sorry for the loss of your child," Mr. Duran said in Spanish, according to a translator who works for the courts. Ms. Soto leaned forward, put her head on her knees and began to sob. Pearl Velez, Mr. Duprey's partner, held her.

"I never wanted this to happen," Mr. Duran said as he held back

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LEBANON Walking in Beirut on Thursday in the midst of destruction at the site of an airstrike.



IRAN Commemorating the 40th day since Ayatollah Ali Khamenei's death on Thursday in Tehran.



ISRAEL Transferring a patient from an underground shelter to a hospital on Thursday in Tel Aviv.

As Planet Warms, Hockey Rinks Turn to Plastic

By KEN BELSON  
and HIROKO TABUCHI

ASHLAND, Neb. — To Michael Townsend and his co-workers, maintaining an outdoor rink as the winters get warmer felt like a Sisyphean task.

Mr. Townsend and his crew increasingly worked overtime flooding the rink at Eugene T. Mahoney State Park in Ashland, Neb., with water and driving a Zamboni throughout the night to maintain the ice.

When the 26-year-old rink needed to be replaced in 2024, Mr. Townsend found that new compressors to chill the ice and pipes underneath the rink would cost \$2 million, a steep price for a rink that attracts about 7,500 skaters a season.

So the park replaced the ice with high-density polyethylene, which is durable, easy to assemble and cheap to maintain. This plastic surface also performs largely

like ice, albeit with more friction, and skaters use regular ice skates. The price tag? About \$350,000, including maintenance supplies.

"It was a needed transformation," said Mr. Townsend, who is himself an avid skater. "It was going to be no skating or look for something that was more cost efficient."

Climate change has wreaked havoc with many sports. Increasingly, severe storms delay golf and tennis matches. Intense heat has led to mandatory water

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A rink in Ashland, Neb., recently replaced ice with polyethylene.

Israel Agrees to Talks  
With Lebanon but Vows  
No Letup on Hezbollah

Behind the Scramble  
for a Cease-Fire

Iran and Europe Say  
Truce Is in Danger

This article is by Tyler Pager, Katie Rogers and Farnaz Fassihi.

WASHINGTON — President Trump sat behind the Resolute Desk as Tuesday evening approached, ruminating about what might unfold in the next few hours.

He had vowed to wipe "a whole civilization" off the map if his 8 p.m. deadline for Iran to reopen the Strait of Hormuz had passed. As a series of unrelated meetings unfolded, Mr. Trump would interject to list the number of bridges and power plants he was prepared to strike in Iran.

He was briefed about Iranians gathering on those bridges and in front of those power plants. He watched the images of people gathering around the structures on television, and told aides it would be the Iranian government's fault if U.S. forces struck and killed them. He called Iranian leaders "evil" for putting innocent people in harm's way.

Then in the middle of the afternoon in Washington, an encouraging message about an agreement taking shape was vetted by the White House and posted on social media by Pakistan's prime minister. Shortly after, an agreement that was hastily brokered by a series of mediating governments, including Pakistan and China, reached a president who was looking for a way out of a deeply unpopular war.

The victory lap started quickly: Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth and Gen. Dan Caine, the chairman of the Joint Chiefs of Staff, declared on Wednesday morning that all their military objectives had been achieved in what Mr. Hegseth called "a historic and overwhelming victory on the battlefield."

But less than one day after Mr. Trump had logged on to social media to announce a truce, the fragile accord was showing signs of fraying, in large part because the two nations would not publicly agree to a shared set of goals for ending the war.

After a tumultuous 36 hours

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This article is by Aaron Boxerman, Amelia Nierenberg, Christina Goldbaum and Michael Levenson.

JERUSALEM — Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu of Israel said on Thursday that he had ordered his government to start direct negotiations with Lebanon on disarming Hezbollah, on a day when President Trump urged restraint by Israel and European leaders warned that Israeli attacks in Lebanon threatened to unravel the fragile cease-fire in the war with Iran.

But in a statement to Israelis shortly after he made the announcement, Mr. Netanyahu declared that "there is no cease-fire in Lebanon" and that Israel was "continuing to strike Hezbollah with force and will not stop until we restore your security."

The Israeli military issued new evacuation warnings for the southern outskirts of Beirut, the Lebanese capital, which were among the densely populated areas pummeled by heavy Israeli airstrikes on Wednesday. Lebanon's health ministry said more than 300 people had been killed and more than 1,000 others wounded in those attacks, making it the deadliest day since the latest war between Israel and Hezbollah began last month.

On Thursday night, Israel said it had launched new strikes on Lebanon and Hezbollah said it had fired rockets into northern Israel.

The United States and Israel have said the two-week cease-fire with Iran, which was announced on Tuesday, does not extend to Lebanon, contradicting both Pakistan, which helped broker the truce, and Iran.

Iran has suggested it could pull out of the deal if Israeli attacks in Lebanon continue, even as Iranian leaders and Trump administration officials prepare for talks this weekend in Pakistan aimed at achieving a long-term peace agreement.

European leaders argued pointedly on Thursday that Israel's attacks in Lebanon were undermin-

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NEWS ANALYSIS

Suez Signaled Britain's Slide.  
Could Iran Do That for U.S.?

By STEVEN ERLANGER

BERLIN — Historical analogies are never exact. But with the tenuous cease-fire deal in the U.S.-Israeli war against Iran, some are asking whether this is a "Suez" moment for the United States, marking the waning of American power and credibility in the world.

The Suez crisis took place in October 1956, when Britain, France and Israel attacked Egypt to force open the Suez Canal. President Dwight D. Eisenhower, with an election days away, ordered them to stop. Prime Minister Anthony Eden of Britain resigned. President Gamal Abdel Nasser of Egypt became a hero of anti-colonialism.

Suez became shorthand for the moment that Britain, exhausted from World War II, gave way as a global power to the United States.

There are differences from that time. The Suez Canal is man-made and wholly in Egyptian territory, unlike the international waterway of the Strait of Hormuz. There is no other global power capable of replacing



A ship sunk by Egyptians to block the Suez Canal in 1956.

America in the region, let alone ordering President Trump around.

But the two-week cease-fire leaves the Islamic Republic in place and still in command of the future of the Strait of Hormuz, with Iran's nuclear stockpile and ballistic missile program unresolved. After Mr. Trump's declaration of victory, however hollow, it is difficult to imagine a resumption of full-scale war.

For the rest of the world, the war "is starting to look like a

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BUSINESS B1-5

No Blue-Collar Boom

President Trump's tax and tariff policies haven't delivered promised jobs, narrowing young workers' options. PAGE B1

Cracking the Pistachio Market

Iran was the world's largest exporter of the nut until trade embargoes allowed California to take its place. PAGE B1



INTERNATIONAL A4-9

Pet Toy to Deadly Drones

After Petcube, a Ukrainian entrepreneur turned to explosives-carrying quadcopters for the battlefield. PAGE A4

A Plan to Remake Germany

If the Alternative for Germany party wins control of a state this fall, it could begin an overhaul of society. PAGE A6

OBITUARIES A17

A Wide-Ranging Photographer

Nathan Farb captured subjects as diverse as New York City in the Summer of Love, Siberia under Soviet rule and the remote Adirondacks. He was 85.

NATIONAL A10-16

A Crew's Most Dangerous Leg

After a flight around the moon, the Artemis II astronauts are relying on a flawed heat shield to protect them as they re-enter the atmosphere. PAGE A14

First Lady Slams Rumors

Responding to what she said were smears, Melania Trump said she had no ties to Jeffrey Epstein and no knowledge of his abuse. PAGE A13

Made in U.S.A.? Not the Steel.

ArcelorMittal, a European company, is said to be donating tens of millions of dollars in steel for President Trump's White House ballroom project. PAGE A13

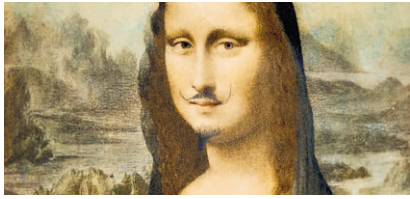
WEEKEND ARTS C1-12

A Tragic 'Salesman' Revisited

Arthur Miller's classic play has returned to Broadway, and yet again, our critic says, it is a triumph. PAGE C1

His Own Take on Art

An exhibition at MoMA shows how Marcel Duchamp charted his own course. Below, "L.H.O.O.Q." PAGE C1



SPORTS B6-10

Oh, Give Me a Home . . .

After a \$60 million repair, the Rays returned to Tropicana Field, but they really want a new stadium. PAGE B6

Milwaukee's Murky Future

As the Bucks' disappointing season winds down, the team's G.M. fielded questions about what is next. PAGE B8

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Kate Marvel

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